U.S. RENTER INCOME / 2015-2024

Higher prices did not erase the gain in this modeled ratio

51.8%

Growth in renter median household income

40.6%

Growth in the illustrative selected-essential budget

The model covers rent, food at home and gasoline. It does not capture every expense or every household.

Sources: Census ACS 1-year, BLS CPI-U, EIA. Illustrative fixed budget.

ONE TRANSPARENT RATIO

Affordability index: 108.0

2015 = 100

Income relative to 2015 divided by modeled costs relative to 2015.

Above 100 indicates improved modeled purchasing power for the selected costs.

The 2015 budget: $1,000 monthly rent, $400 groceries, $150 gasoline. These are illustrative amounts, not an observed average household.

Annual comparison stops in 2024. Standard ACS 2020 remains missing. Aggregate median income does not follow the same households over time.

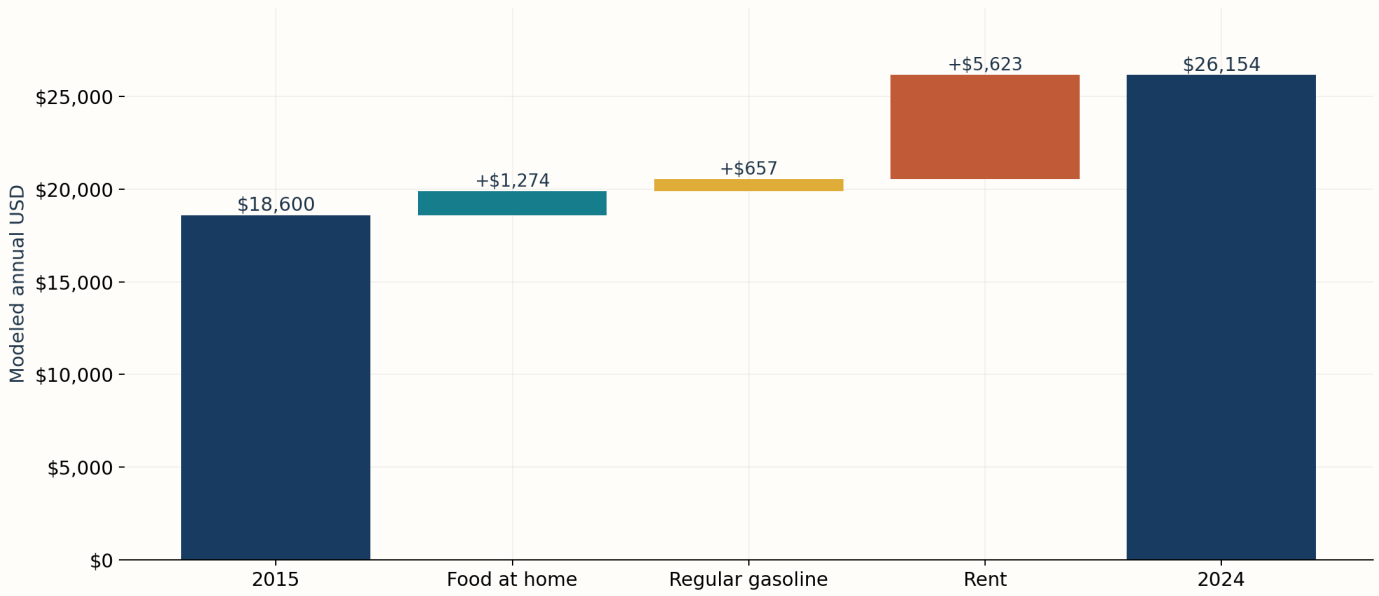
Sources: Census ACS renter income; BLS / EIA price relatives. Model v1.

Rent explains most of this model's increase

$5,623

of a $7,554 modeled annual increase (74.4%)

Rent adds the most dollars under the primary budget weights
U.S., 2015–2024; fixed illustrative category budgets



Source: BLS CPI / EIA. Contributions depend on baseline weights; they do not describe observed household spending.

The contribution depends on rent's large starting weight as well as its price movement.

Sources: BLS rent / grocery CPI, EIA gasoline. Baseline $18,600/year.

A rent-to-income proxy is different from actual burden

Florida: 38.5%

Annualized median gross rent divided by renter median income.

Florida: 62.1%

Share in rent-burden bands of 30% or more, among cases with a computable burden.

Different denominators answer different questions. State point estimates carry uncertainty. National grocery and gasoline prices do not become state prices.

Source: Census ACS 1-year 2024, B25064 / B25119 and B25070.

GASOLINE AND GROCERIES / MONTHLY

Changing the metric changes the relationship

r = 0.751

Price levels, 140 paired months

r = -0.073

Consecutive monthly changes, 138 valid pairs

Trends, seasonality and shock periods matter. Descriptive lags do not establish gasoline causing grocery inflation.

Sources: BLS food-at-home CPI / EIA regular gasoline, 2015-Sep 2026.

Which assumptions would change your conclusion?

Replace the budget weights. Inspect the state housing definition. Test income, rent, grocery and fuel scenarios.

Python collects and validates the sources. DuckDB SQL builds the model. The dashboard exposes the assumptions.

Omitted costs include taxes, healthcare, childcare and utilities. Selected-essential affordability is only part of financial well-being.

Explore the dashboard and inspect the methods:
github.com/amanubhi/american-affordability-index

Sources: Census, BLS and EIA. No causal or reliable forecast claims.